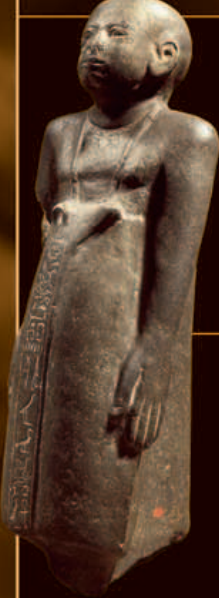


Complex civilizations developed along the river valleys of the Tigris and Euphrates in the Middle East, the Nile in Egypt, the Indus in India, and later, the Yellow River in China. Trade, increasing prosperity, and technological advances produced increasingly powerful centralized states, and in time, empires. These factors also brought many of these

new societies in conflict with each other, particularly in the relatively highly populated Middle East, where Egyptians, Hittites, Assyrians, and Babylonians successively embarked on waves of military conquest. More enduring was Bronze Age China, which flourished from about 1800 BCE. In Europe, culture was most sophisticated in Crete, from around 2000 BCE.

2000 BCE		1800 BCE		1700 BCE		1600 BCE	
c. 2000 Trading city of Ashur becomes predominant in north Mesopotamia. Middle Kingdom Egypt run by powerful officials, such as viziers. ▼ Middle Kingdom vizier, Egypt			c. 1755 Law code of Hammurabi of Babylon displayed on monumental stelae (memorial stones) in temples throughout Mesopotamia. ◀ Shang bronze vessel			c. 1600 Mycenae, Greece, emerges as center of civilization in Aegean; development of Linear B script by Mycenaeans. Hittite statuette ▶	
	1965 Sesostris I of Egypt conquers Nubia and extends southern frontier of Egypt to the second cataract of the Nile. c. 1900 City of Erilou develops on the Yellow River, China.	c. 1800 Beginnings of Shang state, China. Possible sun worship in Scandinavia, indicated by bronze artifacts. Long-distance trade networks established in North America. In Peru, ceremonial center of La Florida built.			▲ Hittite capital, Hattusha c. 1650–1550 During Second Intermediate Period, Lower Egypt ruled by the Hyksos, a warrior elite of Asiatic origins; Upper Egypt ruled from Thebes by native kings.		
	c. 1900–1700 Indus Valley civilization declines. c. 1894 Old Kingdom of Babylon established in Mesopotamia. c. 1890 Short-lived empire of Shamshi-Adad unites north Mesopotamia: a precursor to Assyria.			c. 1700 Most cities of the Indus Valley civilization deserted. c. 1680s Development of leavened bread in Egypt.		1595 Hittite king Mursili II sacks Babylon: end of Hammurabi's dynasty and the Old Kingdom of Babylon. 1500s The Kassites, the warrior elite of the fallen Old Babylonian state, gain control over south Mesopotamia.	c. 1570 Egyptian rulers buried in rock-cut tombs in the Valley of the Kings. ▼ Akrotiri ruins
		Phaistos disk, Crete ▲ c. 1763 Hammurabi, king of Babylon, defeats neighboring Elam and conquers and integrates kingdom of Larsa. c. 1757 Babylon controls all of Mesopotamia.			c. 1627 Beginning of several years' global cooling, documented by tree rings, possibly indicates massive volcanic eruption, perhaps of Vesuvius (Italy) or Thera (Minoan–Mycenaean Greece).		
c. 2000–1800 Lapita people begin to settle Melanesia, in the Pacific, from Indonesia. Minoan civilization of Crete at its height; palace of Knossos built; Cretan Linear A script developed. Knossos palace, Minoan Crete ▶			c. 1750 Massive ceremonial architecture at Sechin Alto, Peru. Possible date of the Phaistos disk, Crete. c. 1730 Disintegration of Middle Kingdom Egypt; start of Second Intermediate Period.	c. 1650 Anatolian city-states unite as Hittite Old Kingdom, with capital Hattusha. Arrival of Aryan people in India.			c. 1550 Aryans settle northern India. Rise of Egypt's New Kingdom, with new capital, Thebes, facing the Valley of the Kings. Volcanic eruption on island of Thera buries Minoan town of Akrotiri; Crete falls under Mycenaean control.